

says this approach doesn't diminish ambition but amplifies it. "The best leaders don't just occupy the stage. They make space on it for others," she says.

EVOLVING DEMANDS

From her vantage point in executive search, Toral Patel, Managing Partner at executive search firm Accord Group India, sees a clear shift in what boards and promoters expect from top leaders. "Given the radical pace of innovation and disruption, it is imperative for successful leaders to study, develop, and deeply assess the impact of their response to any business challenge. These factors tend to drive the principles of ambivert leadership," she says.

Patel says early-stage businesses and start-ups, where market and customer development are critical, still need leaders with strong extroverted skills. Client expectations have shifted noticeably in the last four-five years, she says. "The pandemic accelerated the demand for empathy, emotional intelligence, and strategic as well as entrepreneurial thinking. Clients may not always use the word 'ambivert' but the qualities they seek are evolving in that direction," she says. When organisations hire senior talent, they rarely label these qualities as ambivert. Instead, they describe specific combinations of behaviours: "assertiveness with humility," "vision with execution," "big-picture thinking with attention to detail," and "credibility over authority."

Patel says ambiverts leadership can adapt communication and behaviour to different situations and individuals. "Effective ambivert leaders use the empathy and listening skills common in introverts along with the confident communication and social abilities of extroverts to build consensus, foster collaboration, and connect with diverse team members," she says. This nuanced skill set can be harder to assess during executive hiring. "You have to evaluate qualities like deep thinking while recognising that the person may display both introverted and extroverted behaviours in a single discussion," says Patel. This complexity requires more layered evaluations, case studies, empathy-led conversations, psychometric assessments, and deeper reference checks focused on operating style.

On where demand is strongest, Patel believes it is less about industry and more about the stage and context of the business, as well as its cultural DNA. "Mature businesses, larger conglomerates, and scaled organisations often veer towards ambivert traits, whereas start-ups and new-age companies may lean towards extroverted leadership," she says. The demand for ambivert leaders will only increase. "Leadership has never been as complex as it is today. It is essential to cater to multiple, often disparate stakeholders. Ambivert leaders foster an environment of learnability,

INSIDE THE AMBIVERT PLAYBOOK

Why It Works

► **Balanced Presence:**
Quieter, ambivert leaders make employees feel heard and valued

► **Inclusive Influence:**
They connect across personalities, energising teams, knowing when to pause

► **Calm Under Pressure:**
Their composure drives clear, thoughtful decisions even in high-stakes environments

A Skill You Can Build

► **Learned Flexibility:**
Ambiversion can be developed with practice

► **Small Shifts:** Introverts can step up; extroverts can pause to listen

► **Feedback Loop:** Ongoing inputs sharpen balance and self-awareness

Strategic Edge

► **Socially Bilingual:**
Ambiverts project confidence when needed and listen deeply when it counts

► **Trust Builders:**
Their balance creates psychological safety, team loyalty, and steady performance